

Redcoats in line
During the Napoleonic Wars, the British army often fought defensively, maintaining two-deep lines of infantry against the advancing French columns. A company of light infantry *(above)* formed one end of each battalion's line (grenadiers forming the other), and were often detached for skirmishing. They wore green-plumed shakos *(right)* to distinguish them from centre companies.

THE BRITISH TROOPS who fought the armies of Napoleon in the Iberian Peninsula in 1808–14, and at Waterloo in 1815, were mostly recruited from among the lowest strata of society. Their commander, the Duke of Wellington, famously stated: "We have in service the scum of the earth as common soldiers". Yet the red-coated British infantry proved hardy and determined fighters, whether storming a breach in fortress walls or standing up to the test of French firepower and cold steel in open battle.

The vast majority of the men who filled the ranks of the British army during the Napoleonic Wars were volunteers either enlisted for life (in practice, 25 years) or for shorter periods of service permitted in wartime. Wellington described his soldiers' motives for signing up in the most disparaging terms: "Some of our men enlist from having got bastard children – some for minor offences – and many more for drink". There is no question that some soldiers did join the army as a refuge from prison or from other personal difficulties. Men due to stand trial for petty offences such as poaching might enlist to avoid prosecution. Debtors found shelter in the ranks from the pursuits of their creditors. Sheer poverty drove many to enlist, especially among the half-starving Irish, for whom the prospect of regular food was a compelling motive.

THE KING'S SHILLING

Yet the positive attractions of military life also drew eager and ambitious young men to "take the king's shilling". When actively recruiting, a local regiment would put up posters advertising the advantages of a soldier's life, leaving no cliché unused in their appeal to men whose "hearts beat high to tread the paths of glory". A recruiting party – probably an officer, a couple of NCOs (non-commissioned officers), and a drummer – would then set up in a public place to receive volunteers. John Shipp, who enlisted in 1797, later recalled how he was attracted by a vision of a "merry life, muskets rattling, cannon roaring, drums beating, colours flying, regiments charging and shouts of victory!" At the same time, potential recruits were liberally plied with alcohol, and many woke up with a hangover and a lifetime commitment to serve king and country that they wished they had not made.

PATHS OF GLORY

During the Napoleonic Wars, the army expanded so rapidly (forcing many regiments to create new battalions) that recruits were in desperately short supply. As a result, substantial cash bounties were paid as an inducement to enlist, with the sum of 12 guineas on offer in 1805. When even this failed to fill the ranks, large numbers of soldiers were recruited from the militia, a process that came very close to conscription, while preserving the voluntary principle. The militia was a citizen home defence force composed of men selected by ballot and from which transfer to the army was highly desirable; the former afforded all the hardships of military life but none of the adventure found in the army proper.

By these various means Britain was able to raise an army of around 300,000 men by 1813, compared with a peacetime strength of about 50,000. The prolonged period of warfare also created a great demand for officers. These were mostly drawn from the minor aristocracy or the gentry – sons of clergymen made up about a tenth of officer numbers. Although men of some social standing, officers were not necessarily at all wealthy, but the man without money or social connections was unlikely to make a brilliant career. Commissions were obtained mostly by a mix of purchase, patronage, and seniority. A typical officer's career might start with his parents buying him a place as an ensign, the most junior



GREEN-PLUMED LIGHT INFANTRY SHAKO